Data Center News

Think Tank Pennsylvania

Tuesday, October 13, 2026

Data centers would lose power first in a grid emergency

Pennsylvania's utility regulator has put households first in line. On October 1, the Public Utility Commission (PUC) approved a tentative order on emergency load control — the rules for who loses power first when the grid is under severe stress. Data centers would not count as "critical load." They would be curtailed before homes, hospitals, and other essential customers. The order is tentative, with a final version targeted for January 2027. The principle matters now: as data centers add massive new demand to the grid, the PUC is drawing a line that protects ordinary customers when supply runs short. The PUC's position gained force on Monday, when the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (FERC) rejected PJM's bid to shut off data centers during peak demand, ruling that curtailment decisions belong to the states.

https://www.rtoinsider.com/147082-pa-puc-approves-tentative-order-emergency-load-control-procedures/ (RTO Insider)

Homer City data center plan tabled; water-permit hearing is Wednesday

Amazon Web Services (AWS) has filed a preliminary plan for 36 data centers on roughly 1,100 acres at the former Homer City coal plant site in Indiana County, paired with a 4.4-gigawatt gas-fired power plant. On September 9, the county planning commission tabled the plan, starting a review of about 90 days. Separately, the Department of Environmental Protection (DEP) holds a public meeting and hearing this Wednesday, October 14, from 5:00 to 7:30 PM at Homer Center High School on an amendment to the site's water-discharge permit. Written testimony is due by midnight Wednesday.

http://paenvironmentdaily.blogspot.com/2026/09/dep-to-hold-oct-14-meetinghearing-on.html (PA Environment Digest)

Utility bills up about 20 percent since 2024

Pennsylvania households are already paying more. The Independent Fiscal Office (IFO), the legislature's nonpartisan budget office, reports that the average monthly utility statement has risen about 20 percent since 2024. The figure surfaced at an October 7 hearing of the House Energy Committee on the state's electric reliability outlook. "I am very concerned about what those service interruptions would mean for small businesses and households, especially seniors and families with young children," said Committee Chair Elizabeth Fiedler, pointing to projections of blackouts and brownouts by 2030.

https://pahouse.com/InTheNews/NewsRelease/?id=145547 (Pennsylvania House of Representatives)

House panel advances bills to shift grid costs onto big users

Lawmakers are moving to keep data-center costs off household bills. The House Energy Committee advanced three bills: HB 2828 would make large electricity users pay for the grid upgrades they require and allow them to be curtailed on peak days; HB 2755 would end a roughly half-percent profit bonus utilities earn on regional transmission projects; HB 2775 would require an electric-service application before local zoning approval. Floor votes are possible in the legislature's remaining session days this fall.

https://upperdarbynow.com/news/state/pa-house-panel-moves-forward-data-center-costs-utility-profits-proposals/ (PA Capital-Star via Upper Darby Now)

MARK YOUR CALENDAR — WEDNESDAY, OCTOBER 14

Two deadlines, one day. Applications to serve as a panelist at the PUC's November 17 technical conference on data-center costs are due — email CLCATechConference@pa.gov. And DEP holds its public hearing on the Homer City water-discharge permit, 5:00–7:30 PM at Homer Center High School, Homer City; written testimony due by midnight.

David L. Passmore, https://davidpassmore.net